



Security Watch

Windows Woes—Again!

The Problem

Two serious vulnerabilities have been reported, one in Internet Explorer and the other in Microsoft Office. Microsoft has rated both of them as critical.

In the first one, Internet Explorer is targeted by a remote attacker through a specially-designed Web site. When a user views the page through links from Web pages, e-mails, or IM, an arbitrary pre-existing file can be rewritten. This can then lead to remote code execution and allow full control of the system by the attacker.

The second threat—to Microsoft Office—could allow Remote Code Execution. When using vulnerable versions of Office, if a user is logged on with administrative user rights, an attacker who has successfully exploited the vulnerability could take control of the system. The attacker can create new user accounts with the same user rights as the logged-on user.

The Solution

Microsoft has released patches for these vulnerabilities; the patch for Windows XP SP2 running Internet Explorer 7 is at <http://tinyurl.com/2domm9>. The full list of patches for other versions of Internet Explorer on different Microsoft operating systems can be found at <http://tinyurl.com/2866as>. The full list of patches for the second (Office) threat can be found at <http://tinyurl.com/24rv8k>.

come up with new mobile platforms regularly since its Caramel platform in 2003. As a result, they've held a market share of about 80 per cent today over AMD's share that recently fell below 20 per cent, and AMD is also a year late with Puma vis-à-vis Intel's Santa Rosa.

At the Santa Rosa launch, some found no significant appeal to Centrino Pro as compared to its predecessor. India is yet to make available WiMAX infrastructure and operator services. Kedron's features can only be enjoyed after WiMAX is available extensively in India. Except for the upgrade in the chipset and the other new technologies, no strong point to upgrade right now is evident.

Both giants are pacing into the mobile computing space. But until Puma is launched and used, it would be baseless to compare it with Santa Rosa. But it should get interesting then.

IT'S PAYBACK TIME

Patent Infringement?

Back in November, Microsoft signed a deal with Novell for collaborative work in three technical areas, which shocked the open-source community—to see an unusual partnership between a proprietary software

development company and a Linux distribution and development company. Steve Ballmer, Microsoft CEO, on that occasion, said the agreements would help bridge the divide between proprietary software and open source applications. MS and Novell will collaborate in virtualisation, document compatibility, and management.

The key factor in this deal was the legal framework that protected Novell from patent attacks. Microsoft also promised not to assert its patents against individual, non-commercial, open-source developers and pro-Novell code developers. But that got the open-source community thinking: why should Novell be singled out for "protection," and why the move at all? According to one open source developer, if Microsoft succeeded in getting at least one Linux distro to pay royalties on free software distribution, the others would have to pay too. What they feared came to pass.

When the US Supreme Court implemented the latest copyright law for software, there were signals that software patents in terms of innovations in the programs would follow. Microsoft lagged way behind the others in terms of stocking up on software patents, yet they managed to score and now have over 5,000 software patents. Microsoft then took up the cross-licensing strategy and began licensing its patents to other companies (by asking

HOT

Immersive Gaming



What could be better than a game that sucks you in and never lets you go? Why, the fact that you don't have to shell out millions on the hardware! The Wii does it, and we all know how well that went...

Attempted Realism

NOT

Pretty graphics just don't cut it anymore. Sure, the visuals are a treat, but when the concept is tired...Add to that the fact that you have to break the bank to get even mid-range hardware, Solitaire or Minesweeper seem so much better.



them to pay royalties or getting access to that company's patents). Microsoft signed cross-licensing pacts with Sun, Toshiba, Siemens, and SAP.

Microsoft alleged that free open source software infringed over 235 Microsoft patents. For those infringements, Microsoft wanted free and open source software users to pay royalties.

If Microsoft were to pursue the issue of royalties, Linux and FOSS stand to be undermined, of course. Ballmer countered it as a matter of principle. In an interview later in April 2007 after the Supreme Court eased patent standards, he said, "We live in a world where we honour Intellectual Property and



One Silly Question

"What technology component is most like your significant other—and why?"



"Mouse: you cannot do anything without it."
Karan Gawdi



"A Palmtop—she is always in my hand."
Prerit Singh



"Monitor—always in my eyes; he never escapes me!"
Anuragha Rao



"CPU: she is the heart of my system!"
Souravh Shegaonkar



"RAM—He is always short of it"
Sudha Gupta